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★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 51231.64 ▲ 51.77 0.10%

NASDAQ 27193.34 ▼ 1.3%

STOXX 600 625.51 ▼ 0.8%

10-YR. TREAS. (Reopening) yield 5.232%

OIL \$91.49 ▲ \$3.21

GOLD \$4,131.80 ▲ \$18.00

EURO \$1.1213

YEN 157.89

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The U.S. budget deficit** climbed 12% to nearly \$2 trillion in the fiscal year that ended Sept. 30, according to the Congressional Budget Office, hitting its highest level since the pandemic in 2021. **A1**
 - ◆ **The earnings** of America's largest oil refiners are set to go gangbusters in the third quarter, spurred on by the conflicts in the Middle East and the war in Ukraine. **B1**
 - ◆ **Investors think quirks** deepening the bond selloff are running out of steam. Also on Thursday, Brent crude rose 4.1% while the S&P 500 and Nasdaq fell 0.5% and 1.25%, respectively, and the Dow rose 0.1%. **B1**
 - ◆ **American Airlines**, which was responsible for 60% of passengers who were involuntarily bumped from their flights last year, says it will stop the practice. **B1**
 - ◆ **Taylor Farms**, the produce giant linked to the deadly cyclospora outbreak, is suspending certain sales of iceberg lettuce from central Mexico. **B2**
 - ◆ **Spotify has reupped** with star podcaster Joe Rogan, securing licensing rights and ad sales for his show in a multiyear deal. **B3**
 - ◆ **PepsiCo cut** its full-year earnings outlook as it faces inflation, higher ad costs and continued weakness in North America. **B3**
 - ◆ **Microsoft's Xbox** is forming a new division focused on extending its franchises into areas like film and TV. **B4**
 - ◆ **SpaceX plans to buy** cellular spectrum licenses from an investment firm, its biggest move yet into a wireless market dominated by traditional telecoms. **B4**
- ### Worldwide
- ◆ **Iran and its Houthi allies** in Yemen delivered a one-two punch against Persian Gulf oil producers in separate attacks that sent oil prices sharply higher and further shattered the sense of security in the Saudi capital. **A1**
 - ◆ **Kimberly Guilfoyle's text** messages with a MAGA ally show her seeking \$100,000 for her Amex account and offering access to top officials before her confirmation as ambassador to Greece. **A1**
 - ◆ **Nicolás Maduro** and his wife were charged with conspiring to commit torture, as part of what U.S. prosecutors said was a scheme to maintain power in Venezuela. **A3**
 - ◆ **The Pentagon plans** to livestream the firing-squad execution of a former Army psychiatrist who killed 13 people in a 2009 shooting at Fort Hood in Texas. **A4**
 - ◆ **The Trump administration** is suspending several tech firms, alleging they abuse a program that allows H-1B visa holders to apply for green cards. **A3**
 - ◆ **An ICE officer** shot and injured a man in New York City. Mayor Zohran Mamdani said officers surrounded the man while he was in a car with a 5-year-old child and fired. **A3**
 - ◆ **A congressional candidate** in Arizona said she was attacked by two men and raped while fixing a campaign sign near Phoenix after midnight this summer. **A4**
 - ◆ **A Russian airstrike** hit two buses in Ukraine, killing at least 30 people. **A9**
 - ◆ **Canadian poet** Anne Carson was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature. **A8**

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Russian Strike on Ukraine Buses Kills at Least 30



DEVASTATING TOLL: A Russian glide bomb struck two civilian buses Thursday near a stop in the eastern Ukraine city of Kramatorsk, killing at least 30, officials said. One of the destroyed vehicles is seen in a photo provided by the government. **A9**

‘Honey Please’: Guilfoyle Pushed Donor to Wire \$100,000 to Amex

Text messages with a MAGA ally show her offering access to top officials

Kimberly Guilfoyle was preparing for her congressional hearing to become U.S. ambassador to Greece when she reached out to a Trump donor with an urgent request: She needed \$100,000 that she said she owed American Express—in a way that wouldn't leave a paper trail.

“It won't show up anywhere if you wire money to American Express,” she wrote on Signal, according to mes-

sages reviewed by The Wall Street Journal. “Please.”

For months, Guilfoyle had been chatting with Eric Deters, a former congressional candidate in Kentucky who was seeking her help in getting the attention of the new Trump administration on some personal tax and legal issues—and had promised payments of as much as \$1 million if she was successful. As Donald Trump Jr.'s former fiancée, Guilfoyle offered to use her sway, according to Deters and messages reviewed by the Journal. She forwarded Deters the messages she'd sent to the new Internal Revenue Service chief and updated him on her ef-

By Dana Mattioli, Drew Hinshaw, Rebecca Ballhaus and Joe Parkinson

forts to lobby the Justice Department on his behalf.

But her confirmation was coming up, and she needed her card balance paid down before then, she said.

“Honey please I need you to get this done for me today,” she texted Deters, adding a prayer hands emoji and a PDF with bill payment instructions from American Express. “You could just send it here,” she wrote on July 3, 2025, just days before her July 9 confir-

mation hearing.

Deters didn't ultimately make the payment, telling Guilfoyle it would cost him his marriage. But the back and forth, part of a tranche of hundreds of messages, emails and letters reviewed by the Journal, raises new questions about the activities of one of America's most high-profile ambassadors.

Last week, Guilfoyle came under fire from Democrats on the Senate and House foreign affairs committees, who urged the State Department to review her conduct. They cited a Journal investigation into her promotion of a Greek company

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Buyers See Boon Despite Rate Rise

Mortgage rates have hit their highest point in nearly three years, but it turns out there is a silver lining for some home buyers. The upward pressure on borrowing costs is starting to force sellers in some metro areas to cut their prices, giving buyers a glimmer of relief. **A2**



U.S. Budget Hole Gets Deeper As Deficit Nears \$2 Trillion

By RICHARD RUBIN

WASHINGTON—The U.S. budget deficit climbed to nearly \$2 trillion in the fiscal year that ended Sept. 30, according to the Congressional Budget Office, deepening the federal government's persistent red-ink trend.

The \$1.993 trillion deficit was 12% above the 2025 level in nominal dollars, reaching the highest level since 2021. The U.S. spent \$74 trillion last year, up 6%, and it collected \$5.4 trillion in revenue, up 3%.

The deficit also stayed high as a share of gross domestic product, the metric that economists watch closely. Although the final fiscal 2026 GDP number hasn't been released yet, budget experts expect the deficit to surpass 6% of GDP, compared with 5.8% in fiscal 2025.

The CBO's preliminary full-year deficit reading shows the country's finances stuck in an unusual rut that alarms policymakers but hasn't moved them to change course. Six-plus years into an economic expansion, the U.S. is running

annual deficits normally seen only during recessions and wars. This year's jump in bond yields makes the fiscal trajectory even more challenging because it drives up annual interest costs on the \$32 trillion publicly held debt.

The Trump administration and the Republican-controlled Congress took several steps to reduce red ink since gaining full control of Washington in early 2025. They shrank the federal workforce, curtailed clean-energy tax

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900 Miles and a Bag of Change: The Quest to Save Pay Phones

Army of ‘phone spotters’ is racing against the clock to rescue the U.K.’s red booths

By JAMES HOOKWAY

PENNAN, Scotland—William Arnold drove 900 miles from his home in Cornwall this summer to a windswept pay phone on the Isle of Lewis. When he got there, he pulled out a big bag of coins and started making calls, 52 of them to be precise.

In doing so, he ensured the phone booth met the minimum threshold of a call a week to stay in service another year. He also inspired others to do their bit to save the last of the public pay phones.

“There seems to be this

hankering for real, tangible experiences, and a lot of this is borne out in things like the increase in sales of vinyl records,” said Arnold, a photographer and university lecturer when he isn't hunting down remote phone boxes. “Making a phone call the old way fits in with that, just hearing the way the line hums before putting a coin in.”

All the talk of an AI apocalypse in recent months may be encouraging the idea that we should preserve some tools that could come in handy in a de-digi-

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TOMORROW



WSJ. MAGAZINE

ERLING HAALAND

Personal AI Agents Are Great Until They Blab Your Bank Info

By KATHERINE BINDLEY

Shane Mac had been using a personal AI agent since August without issue when the startup chief executive got pinged by one of his employees: a “heads up” about a team Slack message that had a screenshot attached.

There before him was a literal snapshot of his checking and savings account balances, various construction costs for a house project and recurring charges for Netflix and car insurance, courtesy of his agent.

“My heart kind of dropped,” says Mac, who lives in Nashville, Tenn. “I thought I had things set up as separate, personal and work.”

Mac had been using Grok Bot, SpaceXAI's “always-on agent,” giving it read-only access to his bank accounts and naming the agent “Personal CFO.” He maintains a separate Grok Bot agent linked to his work Slack, which he named “Chief of Staff.”

Mac demanded to know how Personal CFO had ended up posting his info to the company Slack. The bot explained itself, then sort of apologized: “That's on me,” it said. “Wrong audience for personal cash—period.”

People are being wowed by the capabilities of their personal AI agents before being quickly brought back down to Earth.

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